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The pragmatics of conducive questions in academic discourse

Roberta Piazza*

School of European Studies, University of Sussex, Falmer, Brighton BN1 9SH, UK

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Abstract

This paper deals with the conducive questions asked by tutors and students who try to convey their preference for a given answer from their hearer/s. In interpreting such questions, textual and contextual elements play a crucial role; in fact the view proposed here is that, beyond the level of formal conduciveness inherent in such questions, conduciveness is really the result of the overall stream of conversation and can only be adequately analysed in pragmatic terms. The paper expands and develops a prior model for the analysis of conducive questions which hinges on the concept of the polarity that exists between a questioner's old belief underlying the question, the new assumption s/he formulates in his/her mind, the expected answer and the formal aspect of the question itself. Some classes of conducive questions are defined which express different degrees of conduciveness and convey different discourse functions. The study can also bear some practical relevance for international students as it offers an insight into an aspect of the academic discourse produced within university seminars in England and, to a lesser extent, Italy and sheds light on some of the effects of the asymmetry inherent in the tutor-students role. © 2002 Elsevier Science B.V. All rights reserved.

Keywords: Conduciveness; Assumption; Negative/affirmative polarity; Asymmetry; Questions; Academic discourse

1. Introduction

This paper[1] analyses a special kind of question asked by tutors and, to a lesser extent, students during some university undergraduate seminars, which were recorded

* Phone Tel.: +44-1273-606755; Fax: +44-1273-623246; Email: r.piazza@sussex.ac.uk.

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at two universities in England and Italy a few years ago. The questions that are investigated here are conducive questions through which questioners try to push their beliefs and views onto their hearers.

The decision to observe conducive questions comes from the belief that they are an expression of academic discourse and an important manifestation of the interaction between tutors and students, which is characterised by asymmetry due to the imbalance of knowledge and authority between the participants. The power dimension, however, is not the focus of the present paper, which aims to investigate conducive questions from a pragmatic perspective and propose a model for their interpretation. The study attempts to offer an understanding of one aspect of the speech act of questioning in terms of the textual and contextual elements it manifests. The view of conduciveness expressed here is that there is a bedrock of structural conduciveness located in the speakers and possibly agreed by speakers and hearers. But over and above this structural level there is a strand of conduciveness that comes out of the stream of conversation. This strand is located in the hearer and is part of the perlocutionary effect produced by the individual speech act of questioning.

The analysis proposed in this paper is of theoretical relevance, yet it has also a practical interest. Conducive questions are one of the features of academic discourse which needs to be explored in all its complexity if students belonging to an international academic community are to be prepared to efficiently participate in university exchanges. The ultimate goal is to comprehend in full the ability to formulate, as well as interpret and respond to, complex conducive questions in a university seminar in which "the tutor is regarded as the main authoritative source of knowledge, with students providing input on the basis of their preparation" (Klerk, 1995: 158). In such a context, "the power and superiority of the role of the (...) academics to the undergraduate are shown by the heavy command load carried by their questions" (Athanasiadou, 1991: 113); questions which the students are expected to answer. Pragmatics sheds light on the mechanisms through which speakers toy with the underlying presupposition of their questions and hence improves our understanding of the academic interaction within seminars or at least of one aspect of it. It is hoped that the insights proposed in this study would provide tutors and students with a more informed view of how academic discourse works.

2. Methodology

The topic of this investigation is the concept of conduciveness. A conducive Q is one that conveys a questioner's expectation of and preference for a given answer as opposed to a Q which does not manifest such an expectation or preference (Stenström, 1984: 47).

Let us compare the two questions below, (1) and (2). In some contexts the former can be taken as a neutral request for information while the latter can be taken as a conducive question which manifests a clash between the questioner's old belief that the hearer was still working at SEI and the new information to be assumed, i.e. that the hearer no longer works there:

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(1) A: Where did you gò?
B: London
(2) A: Aren't you at SEI anymòre?
B: Oh no I left ages ago.

Although a question may be seen as a separate entity from its answer, in the case of conducive questions, the first part of an adjacency pair is directly related to its second part as it influences the answer by asking the answerer to "conform to the underlying presupposition of the question" (Shuy, 1995: 208). Conducive Qs are closed Qs that are generally seen as controlling and powerful, especially in such contexts as courtroom questioning (Bülow-Møller, 1992: 85); with the use of conducive (or coercive) Qs the examiners impose their own interpretation on the evidence (Woodbury, 1984).

When considering conduciveness, we are dealing with a context-based rather than an absolute notion. Also we are dealing with a speaker's formed beliefs or presuppositions. As Levinson (1983: 167) has made clear with reference to the concept of presupposition, this is a kind of pragmatic inference which is closely related to the linguistic form of an utterance; however, one cannot regard presupposition as a purely semantic matter, as too much of the inference is context-bound. Caffi defines pragmatic presuppositions as a 'ménage à trios' between a speaker, the framework of his/her utterance, and an addressee, sees them as an agreement between interlocutors and insists that presuppositions concern the speech act that a given utterance performs and the conversational move which is performed via that speech act (1994: 3321). Most importantly, as Caffi points out, "pragmatic presuppositions are not directly linked to the lexicon, to the syntax, or to the prosodic facts [...], but to the utterance act" (1994: 3321).

Hence an analysis of the conduciveness of questions will look at the form and semantics of the utterances and also at a series of contextual factors which are indispensable to an understanding of the implications of the speech acts under observation. Conduciveness, then, is a purely pragmatic feature but it interacts with such grammatical features as negation, affirmation and with prosody (Bublitz, 1981: 853).

Not all conducive Qs have the same conducive force; they may be seen as more or less conducive according to the real or apparent dominance of the speaker. The criteria for a classification of conducive questions are pragmatic; it will be shown how a number of variables contribute to the interpretation of questions as being suggestive of a particular answer. The power relationship between the interlocutors, the entire text on the interaction, and within it the amount of information exchanged; the place in discourse where the question occurs; the questioner's insistence on a given topic; the repetition and reinforcement of a Q; these are all elements that come into play and activate the co-operative principle of conversation (i.e. be relevant, brief, clear, orderly, truthful, and as informative as need be; cf. Grice, 1975); hence they have an essential role in the analysis of questions. As interpreters and external observers of an interaction, we must look at the answer that a given question receives from the hearer as an indication of the illocutionary force of a speech act. What is proposed here, then, is a pragmatic, hearer-oriented model of conduciveness

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Table 1
Bublitz's model of conduciveness[a]

Example	Original assumption	New assumption	Sentence form	Expected answer
	(*I thought you were still at SEI*) +	(*I think you may no longer be at SEI*) −	−	(*You are no longer at SEI*) −

+ = affirmative polarity, − = negative polarity.
[a] Cf. Bublitz (1981: 859).

which considers the assumptions[2] underlying a question and which views the hearer's response as an integral part of the picture.

I have taken a major study of conduciveness as my starting point, namely Bublitz's analysis of y/n Qs in English (1981), and his concept of the polarity that is inherent in all four elements that constitute a conducive Q: the old assumption or formed belief underlying the speakers'Q, the new assumption they have come to formulate in their mind, the expected answer and the syntactic form of the Q. Bublitz defines various categories of conducive y/n questions (and focuses especially on negative ones) which he classifies according to their negative or positive polarity, that is according to the presence of a negative or positive marker in the propositional form of the Q; this polarity is thus overtly expressed by the form. He also establishes classes of conducive questions according to whether a swing of polarity (affirmative v. negative or vice versa) exists between the elements of the conducive Q, the assumptions, the Q form and the answer. As an illustration example (2) quoted earlier can be represented as follows (Table 1).

The model proposed here partly uses Bublitz's classification of conducive y/n questions, although in a slightly expanded version that incorporates some additional textual elements not present in the original model. It also proposes a further classification for other classes of positive y/n questions.

3. Presentation of the model of conduciveness and discussion of the data

I will now describe an operational model for the analysis of conducive y/n questions with exemplification from my corpus of seminars and will discuss why different kinds of questions have been allocated to different categories. As was said earlier, the proposed classification relies on a formal/textual bedrock as it takes on board the most directly apparent features of the observed questions. However, a number of other contextual elements constitute an integral and unmissable part of the analysis and are brought into the commentary on the various excerpts of academic discourse in this study.

[2] As in Bublitz's work, this study uses the "ordinary, informal term *assumption*" (1981: 854) to refer in a broad way to the speaker's formed, consolidated beliefs in consideration of the more restricted and specific use of the term 'presupposition' in linguistic pragmatics.

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3.1. Openly conducive Qs: two subclasses of negative y/n Qs

3.1.1. The first subclass: open defiance

Bublitz highlights the fact that by asking a conducive question, a speaker (a) causes the hearer to take up the following turn to answer, and (b) exerts his/her influence as to the content of the hearer's answer:[3]

(3)
<T 110> Yeah you define that guilt through the laws ahm, *but don't you define the laws according to how many people you want to be gùilty?*[4]

In the above negative y/n question from a second-year History seminar, the interrogative-negative grammatical form betrays the speaker's expectation of an affirmative answer, in agreement with his assumption but not with the question form. In this particular question the speaker pretends to be inferior to the hearer due to a lack of information, and fakes a change from an old assumption (affirmative polarity: +) to a new one (affirmative polarity again: +): "I thought that X was the case (old) and I still believe in the tenability of this belief (new)". However, the latter assumption is only seemingly denied by the syntax and calls for an affirmative answer (in disagreement with the form) on the part of the hearer. The asymmetry within the tutor-student exchange contributes to interpreting the above Q as heavily conducive.

The particular conversational event—in which a student has given a presentation on witch hunting—justifies the tutor's intervention and his production of a text interspersed with increasingly conducive questions until he reaches the openly conducive

[3] The first restriction of course applies by way of the force of the question alone, independent of its conducive force; the second restriction, on the contrary, only holds in the case of a conducive question.

[4] Transcription symbols

T	Tutor
FSt	Female student
MSt	Male student
+	Short pause
+ +	Longer pause
Te:ext	Stretched vowel
=	Latched-on turns
%text%	Overlapped turns
(? ?)	Inaudible, untranscribable text
(Text)	Uncertain transcription
[*Comment*]	Information on non-verbal behaviour
Text-	Interrupted, incomplete word
Text	Emphasised text
. , ?	Punctuation roughly indicates intonation
"Text"	Title

In this paper, the relevant turns or parts of turns have been highlighted in italics and the significant elements within them are indicated by block letters.

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climax: *but don't you define the laws according to how many people you want to be gùilty?*

(4)

<T 106>	(...) Um by the time the Inquisition gets its hands on the affair um there's pressure on them through the inquisitorial system of investigation and trial to admit that this is a case of of evil witchcraft, because all magic is in fact being put in that category. So the pressure of the judicial system then leads them at the end of the period to be roughly speaking considering though with some resistance themselves as witches. When for quite sometime beforehand they hadn't, so we can see there are cases of the way the judicial system actually transforms the popular mentality, to some extent makes them see [*Someone coughs*] with some injustice these um white witches as as witches which means potentially evil. Now are judicial systems fair? [*Someone coughs*] What rate of conviction do you get? Do you get rate of conviction equals the rate of the number of guilty people?
<FSt 107>	How do you define that guilt though I mean?
<FSt2 108>	Probably (? ?)
<FSt 109>	'course (? ?)
<T 110>	Yeah you define that guilt through the laws ahm, *but don't you define the laws according to how many people you want to be gùilty?*

At that juncture the point the tutor is attempting to force on the student, i.e. the manipulative nature of the justice system at the time of the Inquisition is laid down openly on the conversational floor.

The swing of polarity between the speaker's old and new assumptions is only a matter of pretence in this class of questions; in fact no change has occurred and the speaker still holds his/her assumption. The purpose of the speaker, then, is to get the hearer to agree that "It is the case that X", i.e., that "Laws are not defined absolutely but rather they are defined according to how many people one wants to find guilty". The expected answer, which shows agreement with the assumption underlying this conducive question, is an affirmative one.[5]

While on the syntactic level the negative form of the question indicates an apparent clash between old and new assumptions, the intonation does not always appear to be illuminating.[6] Bolinger (1957) and Stenström (1984) mention downmotion as a symptom of conduciveness. However, up and down motion need not be suggestive of conduciveness and both are compatible with it. While for example in the previous

[5] There can be another reading of (3). One could say that the speaker can display a certain amount of uncertainty as to whether or not the hearer believes that *p*. The speaker then chooses this particular question format because s/he is prompted by some information s/he has that the hearer is possibly not sharing his/her assumptions (Bublitz, 1998, personal e-mail communication).

[6] The same perplexity about the role of intonation in some cases has been expressed by Geluykens (1988), who has pointed out how the role of rising intonation, especially in two kinds of polar questions, i.e. que-claratives (e.g. *This is a question?*) and inversion-questions (e.g. *Is this a question?*), has been overrated.

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extract the intonation beyond the nucleus boundary was falling or, better, flat-falling, in the following similar conducive question (4), prosody is not of much help as the speaker aborts his utterance and changes tack, which results in an incomplete nucleus. Conduciveness is then expressed by other elements and variables, for instance the recurrence of the same Q and the amount of explicit information contained in it as in the excerpt below in which the tutor reiterates his Q in the attempt to get his point across to the student.

(5)
<T 110> Yeah you define that guilt through the laws ahm, *but don't you define the laws according to how many people you want to be gùilty?* Of course this is a suggestion put forward by Al Solman who's actually done some work on the French judicial system and on witchcraft. *So don't you actually write the laws in such a-* if you want to catch child abusers and you have a loose definition of child abusers and you can catch a lot of child abusers in society, there's a sudden fear of child abusers ahm or a sudden marginalization of certain forms of behaviour, you write a law about it and you can therefore catch people for it because the law is vague enough

Although prosodically ambiguous as a consequence of the incomplete intonation nucleus (flat intonation and neither down nor up motion), this speaker can be commended for his conversational clarity when, following the aborted conducive question, he articulates his viewpoint quite explicitly about the laws being formulated *ad hoc* in order to prosecute a special kind of alleged crime and criminal.

It has been shown how a number of elements contribute to an interpretation of the conducive force of questions. The synthetic representation of their features I propose here is bound to appear reductive, yet is necessary for an easy identification of the different types and subtypes of conducive questions I have encountered in my seminars. Not all the elements that the present analysis takes on board can be visibly represented in the tables that follow. However, in addition to the formal characterisation of a Q and the nature of the disparity between its underlying assumptions, I have signalled the presence of relevant textual features, such as the repetition of lexical elements and the maintenance of topic, that are central to the assessment of the in/direct conduciveness of the questions. The graphic representation of the first class of conducive questions is summarised in Table 2.

In conclusion, conducive Qs of the first subclass seemingly express a polarity between the old and the new assumption, are oriented towards an affirmative answer

Table 2
First subclass of negative y/n conducive Qs

Original assumption	New assumption	Sentence form	Repetition	Topic continuity	Expected answer
+	+	–	+	+	+

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and characterised by a negative form. These questions are of the most directly conducive kind. There is only a seeming disparity between the old and the new assumption, which hints at the fact that the questioner is not going to change her/his mind and is irrespective of the stimulus s/he has received from the hearer. Textual elements also contribute to heightening the Q conduciveness, especially the maintenance of the topic, which is expanded on and increasingly clarified via the repetition of lexical elements within the Q and in the adjoining text.

3.1.2. The second subclass: tentative defiance

In the Italian data, the use of conducive questions can sometimes have a directive function, as appears in the following excerpt from a Cultural Anthropology seminar.

(6)

<T>	(...) si ecco allora? Si
<FSt>	Poi sempre Pitti appunto [*Coughs*] dice che la complessità e la specializzazione che la ricerca ha raggiunto a a livelli odierni fa fa—sto seguendo uno schema (? ?)
<T>	Certamente eh
<FSt>	praticamente lo fa dipendere spesso da dei collaboratori stipendiati che sono [*Coughs*] appunto assunti, diciamo tra virgolette, nel posto.
<T>	Si
<FSt>	Però questo non (rispecchia) non (rispecchia) un'immagine globale della verità; cioé non ci si può fidare delle varie competenze delle diverse persone *senza avere prima un'idea generale del tutto*.
<T>	*Ma ma solo per questo? Solo per avere un'idea generale del tutto?*
<FSt>	*No, anche per facilitare% (? ?)% del lavoro*
<T>	%Eh anche perché% ...
<T>	(...) yes, well? Yes
<FSt>	Pitti [*Coughs*] also says that the complex and specialised level reached by today's research makes makes- I'm following a draft (? ?)
<T>	Of course
<FSt>	basically it makes it dependant on some paid collaborators who are [*Coughs*] hired, let's say in quotes, on site.
<T>	Yes
<FSt>	This, however, does not (reflect) does not (reflect) a global image of the truth; in other words, one cannot trust people's various competences *without first having a general idea of the whole thing*.
<T>	*But but only for this? Only to have a general idea of the whole thing?*
<FSt>	No also to ease% (? ?)% of the work
<T>	%Also because% ...

In the above exchange, in response to the student's interpretation ("... in order to have a general idea"), the tutor produces a corrective proposition which is meant to redirect the student onto the right track. The reiteration of the discourse marker *solo*

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(only), together with an evident stress conveying dissatisfaction with the answer, serves as an indirect intervention and solicits the student's self-correction in the following turn. The tutor's assumption is evidently negative and the expectation is of a negative answer. The student's answer reveals a correct detection of the conduciveness contained in the tutor's question and an acceptance of her indirect correction.

In conclusion, conducive Qs of the second subclass express a tension between a negative old and a positive new assumption and are oriented towards a negative answer through a negative form (see Table 3). Although still very directly conducive, these questions are slightly less so than questions in the previous subclass. The same textual elements of repetition are present but there is a real disparity between the old and new assumption, which suggests that the questioner may consider adopting a different viewpoint to her original one.

3.2. Indirectly conducive questions (light/subtle conduciveness): three subclasses of positive y/n Qs

In this section, I will deal exclusively with positive y/n questions, some of which are contemplated in Bublitz's model, and some of which belong to the new categories I have devised. Questions belonging to these classes are much more subtle (and less intrusive), hence far more indirect than the questions examined so far. The far greater indirectness and subtlety of such questions can be partly ascribed to their positive form, which makes it less easy to detect the underlying clash of assumptions in the questioner. However, in some cases textual elements such as repetition within the turn contribute to clarify the degree of conduciveness of these questions.

As was said earlier, this classification is based on the core concept that lies behind Bublitz's notion of conduciveness, notably of a discrepancy existing between an old and a new assumption, each of which may have a negative or affirmative polarity. In the seminars observed I have identified three types of positive y/n Qs, all of which express different combinations of polarity. The criteria for this classification are pragmatic and the elements motivating the assignment of Qs to one or another category are to be looked for in the text, in the role and status of the participants, the interpersonal dynamics between the speakers and in the very context of the exchange, as I will try to show in the pages that follow.

3.2.1. The first subclass: Qs conveying surprise or incredulity

The first class of positive y/n Qs is contemplated in Bublitz's model. Qs in this category express a tension between the Questioner's negative old assumption and his/her positive new belief. Together with the change from the old to the new assumption

Table 3
Second subclass of negative y/n conducive Qs

Original assumption	New assumption	Sentence form	Repetition	Topic continuity	Expected answer
–	+	–	+	+	–

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and from negative to positive, these Qs convey the Questioner's surprise and are oriented towards an affirmative answer as in (7).

(7)
A: I'm going to Oberjoch next week; the skiing facilities there are excellent
B: *Can you skì?*
A: Of course I can.
B: Oh, I always thought you couldn't.
(Bublitz, 1981: 860)

The graphic representation of these Qs is summarised (Bublitz, 1981: 859) in Table 4.

Table 4
First subclass of positive y/n conducive Qs

Original assumption	New assumption	Sentence form	Repetition	Topic continuity	Expected answer
–	+	+	–	–	+

In my corpus of undergraduate seminars, Qs of this type, usually asked by the tutors, often receive an appropriate answer from the students. From the second-year History seminar:

(8)
<MSt 045> (...) There's actually more poverty in the the at least the 15th and early 16th sorry and early 17th century =
<T 046> = uh
<MSt 047> than and is Thomas goes on to say that that that witchcraft dies out because there's an increasing living standard or or suggests at one point (? ?)
<T 048> It wouldn't work on the continent of Europe =
<MSt 049> = no
<T 050> which is in a long-term depression from about [*Someone coughs*] 1630 to 1730. That might work for England. So what about this this ahm argument about social change social distress scapegoats and so on? *Did you find that convìncing?* Obviously Mike does because because he says so [*MSt laughs softly*] the scapegoat theory as it's called
<FSt 051> Ahm a lot of ah like midwives and people like wet nurses they were accused of witchcraft weren't they? Because it was sort of a way of blaming the death of a child rather than blaming the death of a child on midwives so that therefore they were scapegoats to blame for death.
<T 052> But did they accuse them of being witches?
<FSt 053> + + + I don't think they actually accused them of being witches they just said they were bewitching them which were two different things
<T 054> It is different isn't it?
<FSt 055> Yeah.

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In contrast to the conducive questions examined earlier which exhibited a clear insistence on the topic of discussion, the tutor in this case exerts his influence on to the novel content of the Q. His turn (<T 050>) opens with a neutral expository question introducing the new topic, i.e. 'social distress or scapegoat theory' and signals the switch away from the previous theme of the seminar. The choice of the deictic *this* in the opening and orienting question is a technique which the tutor uses for various reasons and purposes: a. 'social distress theory' has been mentioned earlier so *this* signals the topic-reopening move; b. *this* presupposes the hearer's familiarity with and not just knowledge of the topic of discussion. *This* pulls the topic of 'social distress theory' out of the distant anonymous world of the assigned readings and closer to the student's own experience of class discussion. *This* is thus an 'approaching' discourse strategy as opposed to a 'distancing' strategy.[7]

The subsequent question (*Did you find that convincing?*), on the contrary, contains the deictic *that* which, especially in opposition to the previous *this* serves a disowning and distancing function and gives away the speaker's expectation of a critical, if not a negative, consideration of 'social distress theory'. Through such discourse features as deictics, then, the speaker indirectly and subtly hints at his beliefs. He did not believe that X (old), i.e. in the tenability of the 'social distress or scapegoat theory', and is surprised that anybody does, although he is prepared to hear assertions to that effect (new).

Although prosody does not always provide unquestionably reliable support, this Q exhibits some degree of downmotion (from flat intonation in the body to fall intonation at the nucleus) and the accent is on the word *convincing* to indicate the focus of the question. The remaining text in the turn provides evidence for a plausible interpretation of the question as conducive. The tutor mentions the name of a student, Mike, as one of the people who believed in the questionable theory of social distress that he wants to examine. Since Mike is a student who is perceived as losing authority and credibility throughout the seminar, the association of social distress theory with Mike serves the purpose of discouraging the other students from assigning too much value to that theory. Mike's soft laugh is a response to the tutor's mention of his name in public, but probably also to the association of social distress theory with his name as the indication of a mistake that he made or a questionable view he sided with.

In defining conduciveness, Stenström (1984: 47) emphasises the role of perlocution: "What determines whether or not a Q is conducive (...) is neither form nor speaker intention on their own but the way B interprets a particular utterance in a particular situation". The answers to conducive questions are an essential element in the interpretation of questions as conducive in much the same way as the surrounding text can give us additional information for interpretation.[8] Having established that in <T

[7] Similar to other linguistic switches (e.g. the tense/aspect switch in narrative) which have a pragmatic function in that they are a means of expressing focalisation and directing the reader's interpretive process (cf. Fleischman, 1991), the switch from *this* to *that* suggests the questioner's change of perspective towards the question topic.

[8] The degree of conduciveness can be seen in the way a given utterance is perceived by a hearer. "Intended effects are computable at the moment of the utterance and must be assumed as part of the context in which a response is made" (Coates, 1998, personal e-mail communication). However, achieved conduciveness (on the part of the hearer) can be independent of the intended conduciveness (on the part of the speaker) or be contradicted and denied by a questioner.

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050> the expected answer is "not X" and that the speaker's original and new assumption is "not X" (X = social distress theory is convincing), one can look at <FSt 051> as the subsequent turn which initiates a somewhat conflictual sequence. In turn <051> a female student chips in to the rescue of Mike, the student mentioned earlier by the tutor. Turn <051> responds to <050> with a tag question that is highly conducive in its "being nearly an assertion" (Stenström, 1984: 49) and that challenges the assumption of the previous question. In other words, what the student is saying is: If midwives and wet nurses were especially the victims of witch craze, then social distress theory, as the explanation proposed for prosecuting a particular section of the population, is tenable. In conclusion, the conduciveness contained in the tutor's original question in <050> is clearly detected by the student who, in response, produces a defying move.

In a similar case, the response to a conducive y/n Q which imposes a slight change of topic, is a challenging move expressed by another conducive Q:

(9)

<MSt 043> Well this this this one of the things that I read was this sort of analogy of an old woman begging for alms and knocking on the door and if you don't give her alms she'd wander off and curse you and then there you go she's a witch and the the whole process continues off from that

<T 044> *Do you find any èvidence to support that theory?* which is put forward by Alan MacFarlane (to keep promising people) because his student was Alan MacFarlane ah other aspects of the community. It's something that Mike referred to in his his paper and + was referred to earlier as well. *Are there more people more póor people?*

<MSt 045> *(??) wasn't that one of the points that Thomas is máking?* there's actually more poverty in the the at least the 15th and early 16th sorry 16th and early 17th century =

Here the emphasis on *evidence* can be read as an indication that the speaker believes that, in order to accept a theory, one must look for evidence. *Any* may signpost the questioner's limited belief in the possibility of finding evidence in support of social distress theory, which is later described in the non-restrictive relative clause. The choice of predicate adds a significant element. Implicative verbs (cf. Karttunen, 1971, quoted in Levinson, 1983: 181–185) quite openly suggest the implicature behind a given speech act. So for instance in the proposition *John managed/didn't manage to open the door*, what is presupposed is John's attempt at opening the door, *John tried to open the door*. In a similar way although on the plane of the entailment rather than the presupposition, the predicate *find* in *Did you find evidence to support that theory?* expresses the speaker's belief that if the student found evidence, i.e. tangible elements on which to base his judgement of the tenability of the theory, that entails he certainly must have looked carefully for it.

This question too is biased towards an affirmative answer although the questioner contemplates it as a remote possibility. He is sure that scarcely any elements in

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support of the theory can be found, but suspecting an affirmative answer, he decides to hint at a possible trace of evidence, i.e. an increase in poverty. He asks the student to assess that information: "*Are there more poòr people?*"

As with the case discussed earlier, e.g. turn <051> in excerpt (7), the hearer's answer in the subsequent turn is a challenging move. In reply to the tutor, the student produces a y/n conducive question whose expected answer is affirmative. The student has felt threatened by the tutor in his disbelief in the value of the theory he is reporting on (social distress theory). In order to (a) counterbalance the tutor's authority, and (b) shake off responsibility for his statements and gain credibility, he reacts by uttering a conducive challenging question in which he quotes some authoritative source, Thomas, the author of one of the assigned or recommended readings, who maintains that poverty struck in the 16th and 17th centuries.[9] The tutor's intended conduciveness may trigger a series of challenging moves by the students, which in some cases conclude with the student's defeat.

(10)

<T 046>	Uh
<MSt 047>	than and is Thomas goes on to say that that that witchcraft dies out because there's an increasing living standard or or suggests at one point (??)
<T 048>	It wouldn't work on the continent of Europe=
<MSt 049>	=no

As has been seen so far, the response to a conducive Q can often be another Q of the same type. The hearer detects the questioner's attempt to push the exchange in a particular direction and replies in tune with the delicately coercive style of the Q. This often functions as a move challenging the intent of the original Q. However there are alternative replies to a conducive Q; there are cases when a conducive Q in response to a previous conducive Q can be uttered with the purpose of offering support, as in the following exchange (10), from the second-year History seminar quoted earlier.

(11)

<T 112>	... So legal systems can have very precise or very elastic definitions of the crime can't they?
<MSt 113>	*Isn't it yes isn't it true that in the the Catholic countries there was the state [Someone coughs] (? ?) the Catholics burned heretics and the Protestants burnt witches and the vice and the Catholics didn't burn witches and the Protestants didn't burn heretics=*
<T 114>	They did actually

[9] As Hill and Irvine (1993: 6) point out, "[t]he question of authoritativeness arises ... in cases where a speaker's personal identity or social position is somehow insufficient as a guarantee of a statement's truth or authenticity".

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In <MSt 113> the speaker assumes that X, X being: the Catholics burned heretics and the Protestants burned witches, also the Catholics didn't burn witches and the Protestants didn't burn heretics, or put more simply, the Catholics burned heretics but not witches and the Protestants burned witches but not heretics.

Again, as in an earlier case (<MSt 045> in example (9)), a conducive question only seemingly expresses a clash of polarity between an old and a new assumption. The speaker still believes in the old assumption "that X" but pretends to be engaging a revision of it via a negative y/n question. In so doing, the student is expanding on the concept previously expressed by the tutor and trying to provide support for the proposition contained in his Q. As Bublitz points out (1981: 865), the possible answers could be:

Yes = X = "It is true that X" = agreement
No = not X = "It is not true that X" = contradiction.

Since the student's conducive Q in <MSt 113> is intended to be a supportive move for the tutor's previous Q, a likely expected answer could have been an agreement through a affirmative follow-up ("Yes, it is true that X"). However, the hearer, in this case the tutor, decides to choose a negative answer and contradict the student.

<T 114> = They did actually

The latent conflict becomes evident, above all because the tutor's turn is tightly latched onto the student's, thus expressing the tutor's eagerness to contradict the student right away in order to rectify his proposition and prevent his contribution from being taken in by the other student participants as true and tenable.

Conducive Qs of the first subclass express a tension between a negative old and a positive new assumption, may convey the questioner's surprise and are oriented towards an affirmative answer. Generally the highly indirect conduciveness of questions in this class can be explained on the textual level with the limited use of repetition within the Q and in the entire turn and with a tendency to produce a change of topic. The central element however is the real or seeming disparity between the Q's assumptions, which suggests the remote possibility of a change of view in the questioner.

3.2.2. The second subclass: Qs conjuring up an impossible reality

The second class of positive y/n conducive questions is not contemplated in Bublitz's model, which only mentions the case of negative y/n Qs with the same polarity of assumptions. These Qs only seemingly express a disparity between an old and a new negative assumption via a positive interrogative form, and their underlying old and new assumptions are negative. One can say that by asking such Qs, a questioner conjures up a concept or an unrealistic situation that s/he wants the hearer to discard.

The graphic representation of these Qs is as appears in Table 5.

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Table 5
Second subclass of positive y/n conducive Qs

Original assumption	New assumption	Sentence form	Repetition	Topic continuity	Expected answer
–	–	+	+	–	–

(12)

<T 106> (...) When for quite sometime beforehand they hadn't, so we can see there are cases of the way the judicial system actually transforms the popular mentality, to some extent makes them see [*Someone coughs*] with some injustice these um white witches as as witches which means potentially evil. *Now* are are judicial systems fair? [*Someone coughs*] What rate of conviction do you get? *Do you get rate of conviction equals the rate of the number of guilty people?*

<FSt 107> How do you define that guilt though? + I mean

<T 108> Yeah you define that guilt through the laws ahm (...)

Let us take the initial two questions as neutral expository questions that signpost the switch to a new topic in the conversation. These two questions pave the way to the third question in as much as they indicate rate of conviction as a token of fair justice. Finally, in the third conducive question, the speaker voices his belief that justice is NOT fair and points out that the rate of conviction is never the same as the number of people who deserve to be prosecuted (i.e. it is either less or more but never equal to it). While the turn containing the conducive Q introduces a shift of topic in the exchange, the questioner still resorts to some degree of repetition to push his belief on to the hearer. In fact the repetition of the two beginning questions prepares the hearer for the third conducive Q. As in previous cases, one of the students understands the speaker's expectation of a negative answer, yet he prefers a more active role and challenges the tutor by demanding a definition of the notion of guilt. The adversative *though* highlights the defying charge of the turn: the student grants the tutor the truth of his presupposition but questions its principles or criteria.

Conducive Qs of the second subclass seemingly express a tension between a negative old and a positive new assumption, while in fact their old and new underlying assumptions are negative and they are oriented towards a negative answer. Although still rather indirectly and subtly conducive in as much as they are expressed in a positive form, questions in this class are far less indirect than questions in the previous subclass. Again the reason lies in the only seeming disparity of assumptions. The questioner subtly conveys that really s/he has not taken on board any new views. Repetition also contributes to making conduciveness easier to detect even though there may not be much topic continuity.

3.2.3. The third subclass: Qs reinstating the questioner's belief

The third class of positive y/n conducive Qs includes Qs that are also oriented towards an affirmative answer. Like the conducive Qs of the previous category, these

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Qs also express a clash that is only apparent between the old and the new assumption. However, the difference lies in the value of these formed beliefs. While in the previous category the Qs stemmed from a negative old and negative new assumption, these Qs are based on both an old and a new positive assumption.

The graphic representation of these Qs appears in Table 6.

Table 6
Third subclass of positive y/n conducive Qs

Original assumption	New assumption	Sentence form	Repetition	Topic continuity	Expected answer
+	+	+	+	–	+

The following excerpt from a third-year English literature seminar on Milton's *Paradise Lost* opens with a cluster of questions to a student about the sense of inevitability of the fall as linked to sin. The exchange contains, in the middle, the student's answer (<Ben 048>), which is basically rejected by the tutor, and closes with the original questioner's declarative <T 055> (enthusiastically latched onto the student's turn) which openly declares the tutor's belief in the tenability of the assumption he had initially formulated as a question in <T 047>.

(13)

<T 047> Ahm that Satan should find it so easy and so in a way comfortable to fall in with a misogynistic view of Eve but but I- I don't want to close down this issue at all, I want to go back to this question of the whole Adam and Eve disruption at the beginning of book 9 because it seems to be a crucial episode. *Ahm it is the consequence of their being apart at all, Eve's defencelessness in relation to sin? So in a way is it is is there a notion that this is the moment the first moment of erring and from this moment somehow Eve is bound to fall?* + + I mean is that what you'd think Ben? I mean would you *Is the logic that somehow if Eve is on her own* + *she will give in?*

<Ben 048> You mean she's bound to give in

<T 049> [*Laughs*]

<Ben 050> I don't think I don't think it's Milton's aim to show that anything is bound to happen

<T 051> Right

<Ben 052> Ah =

<T 053> = have you noticed, by the way, this is something that seems to me a sort of figurative device that starts to happen during the term but whenever anybody says I don't think it's Milton's aim or I think it's Milton's aim to this is code for I'm not sure about this point but I think if I say that Milton did it [*Students laugh*] then somehow it'll justify my case .... I mean in a way we've done this already, we said but Son says it so therefore it must be true or it must be what Milton thinks that must be true in some sense

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<MSt 054> I think it's hard not to come to that sort of conclusion because is that's gonna happen (? ?) =
<T 055> = So there is this sense of inevitably it will happen because we know it does happen
<MSt 056> Yeah

The cluster of questions in <T 047> is subtly conducive in view of the elements present in the context. The recurrence of the same question, although increasingly more succinctly formulated and more focused, suggests that the questions in <047> are tendentially leading and not at all neutral. A further element to consider is the amount of openly stated information that the questioner deliberately puts in a question. In other words, if a questioner explicitly states a whole conceptually solid proposition to a hearer who has not yet conceived of or teased out the argument in the same explicit way, s/he is forcing a given interpretation of reality on the hearer, at least by overwhelming the recipient with the amount of unsolicited information. And this is probably true even if the question may be devoid of precise formal elements suggesting the speaker's orientation towards a specific answer.[10] Also in this turn, the presence of insistent repetition reduces the degree of indirectness. It is relatively easy to follow the semantic trajectory in the turn from Eve 'being alone' to Eve 'sinning' through the numerous synonyms, e.g. *sin, erring, fall, give in* as a consequence of *being apart, on her own*.

In <048> the student produces a confirmation seeking declarative by which he tries to make sure he has correctly interpreted the intended meaning of his tutor's question. His utterance is misinterpreted by the tutor as the affirmative answer he expected to hear. The tutor's contentment is evident in <049>. But, having verified his interpretation of the tutor's question, in <050> the student produces an unexpected negative answer. What follows in <053> can be summarised as a disapproving move by the tutor who criticises Ben's use of Milton as a direct source of authority (instead of assuming his own responsibility for his statement). The insertion turn produced by the tutor (<T 053>) to disguise his disappointment with Ben's answer triggers a change of interlocutors. The next speaker in the following turn is another student, who produces the affirmative answer the tutor expected (*I think it's hard not to come to that sort of conclusion because is that's gonna happen*). Following that, the tutor utters a confirmation-seeking statement (similar to what Dillon, 1990, calls an "alternative to questioning") that aims to reinforce firmly his point in <055>. Bublitz suggests that the syntactic form of statements like this most directly conveys a questioner's beliefs (as in "A: you don't trust the mìnistry. B: nó I dònt", 1981: 855). The statement receives an affirmative answer from the second student. Agreement is reached and peace at last restored.

One final example derives from a first-year Theatre seminar. Here the conduciveness of the tutor's question is signalled by the presence of prosodic features (for

[10] The justification for an attribution of conduciveness to the tutor's question in <T 047> must be looked for in the whole of the exchange, first of all in the response that the question receives, then in the subsequent turns in which the original presupposition is reinstated and reproposed in another fashion.

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example the heavier intonational weight on a key element in the turn), of semantic elements that are suggestive of the underlying formed belief and finally by such syntactic elements as the use of a disjunctive form. The presence of all these features makes it plausible to interpret the tutor's question as an indirectly conducive Q, the expected answer to which is in fact offered by the tutor after the student's answer.

(14)

<T>	*So this scene is important to show us something about Hamlet as well as to show us something about these characters* ***or*** *do you think it's even* ***more*** *important to show us something about Hamlet?*
<FSt>	You can, you can
<T>	Even more important than showing us + that the function of the scene is really to give us other people's view of Hamlet rather than to give us a view of those characters (...)

Conducive Qs of this last subclass are based on an old and a new positive assumption and are oriented towards an affirmative answer. Repetition within the turn and in the Q plays a central role and greatly contributes to reducing the indirectness.

4. Conclusion

From the discussion it should appear evident that the pragmatic approach proposed here views conduciveness as a hearer-based, hearer-oriented notion, a notion that mostly depends on the interpretation by the hearer. Conduciveness is not a feature totally inherent in the utterance. Rather, speakers can produce an intended conduciveness and hearers can identify conducive power or ascribe it to the utterance. Ultimately it is in the hearer's answer that the key to the interpretation of conduciveness lies.

The analysis of the excerpts from the undergraduate seminars I have proposed here has, I hope, shown that a variety of elements contribute to determining the degree of conduciveness of questions. Conduciveness then appears to be a complex package in which a wide range of textual and contextual elements interact, including form, prosody, repetition and topic maintenance or change, hearer's answer to the question itself, speaker's dominance, relationship to the source of authority (i.e. the assigned reading), etc.

Conduciveness (both direct and indirect) and neutrality are alternative features of the discourse of undergraduate seminars. In the context of academic seminars, the dominant role of the tutor questioning the students plays a central role. The students are more inclined to take Qs coming from their tutor as attempts of the speaker to push a given belief onto them than they probably would if the Qs were produced in a symmetrical exchange. To a certain degree tutors are entitled to encourage acceptance of their views by the audience in the name of their greater knowledge and authority. Classroom dominance and asymmetry, then, are variables in the consideration of conduciveness. However they are not the only element. Another and equally significant variable is the degree of objective information discussed or the relationship established

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between the student-tutor group and the extratextual source of reference which lies behind the class discussions, i.e. the set of primary and secondary readings that the students and the tutor are familiar with. The nature of the disparity between the assumptions underlying a Q—whether real or seeming—contributes to the greater or lesser degree of indirectness; the textual elements in a conducive Q, its formal aspect (whether it is a negative or a positive y/n Q) also have an impact on the way it is responded to by a hearer. It has been shown how the negative y/n conducive Qs in the first group are more direct and explicit, while their positive counterparts exhibit a more subtle conduciveness. However even within this second sub-category, slight differences can be detected.

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Roberta Piazza received a first degree in Modern Languages in Italy, and later obtained an Ed.D. in Applied Linguistics from Teachers College, Columbia University, New York and an M.Phil. in Linguistics from the University of Sussex, UK, where she is currently an Italian government-sponsored lecturer in Italian. She has taught Italian as a foreign language in the US and UK and worked as a teacher trainer in Italy. She has published in the area of English and Italian linguistics especially discourse analysis and pragmatics related to academic discourse, the language of televised news and the discourse of theatre and cinema.